

The Most Politically Incorrect Thing About Me

Wueh!!!

Let me confess something before someone exposes me.

I have trust issues.

Not with people. Well I do have with people but that's a story for another day.

With job descriptions.

If I walk into an electronics shop and a woman approaches me smiling,

"Hi! Looking for anything today?" My brain immediately starts scanning the room.

"Excuse me... where's your colleague?" The colleague? A man. I know.

I'm already going to hell.

Now before you sharpen your keyboards, hear me out.

I don't think women are incapable.

That's what makes this whole thing so confusing.

I know women who can wire an entire house. Women who build gaming PCs for fun.

Women who probably know more about processors than Intel's marketing department.

Women who can install a washing machine, fix a leaking tap, and somehow still remember everyone's birthday.

I know all this.

But eish...

If my shower starts leaking, my spirit automatically starts looking for a fundi called Kamau.

Not Faith. No offense to the Faiths I know.

If I need someone to recommend a microwave, my neck starts turning until I spot a man in a branded polo shirt with a tape measure hanging somewhere around his waist for absolutely no reason.

The funny thing?

That same man could have started working there yesterday.

The woman could have trained him.

She could have written the manual.

She could literally have helped design the microwave.

My brain still goes,

"Hmm... but let's hear what Kevin has to say."

It's even worse in a hardware.

Hardwares are where all my progress as a modern human being goes to die.

You know those places where every aisle has fifty different screws that all look identical but apparently have different destinies?

If I ask for one thing and a woman confidently says,

"Aisle three. Third shelf on your left."

My brain goes,

"Are you... sure?"

As if she's the one asking me for directions.

Then a man walks over and repeats the exact same sentence.

Suddenly I'm convinced.

"Aah! That's what she meant."

Tell me that isn't ridiculous.

Or nyama choma.

If I'm driving and I see two smoky joints opposite each other, one run by a guy named Oti and the other by a woman named Susan, my steering wheel starts making decisions without consulting me.

Straight to Oti.

No evidence.

No reviews.

No tasting.

Simply vibes.

Meanwhile Susan could be out there producing meat so tender that ancestors rise to applaud.

But my brain has already voted.

Why?

Because somewhere in my subconscious, there's a committee that still believes all men are born knowing two things.

How to reverse into impossible parking spaces.

And how to roast meat.

Neither is true.

I've seen men reverse until pedestrians started giving instructions.

I've eaten nyama choma that fought back.

Some of these famous "grill masters" should honestly be arrested.

How do you make meat dry and raw at the same time?

That's not cooking.

That's witchcraft.

The funny part is I don't even apply this consistently.

If I'm looking for a tailor, my brain suddenly starts looking for a woman.

Need someone to braid hair?

Woman.

Need someone to decorate a wedding?

Woman.

Need someone to choose curtains?

Woman.

See?

The bias isn't against women.

It's against certain jobs.

Somewhere in my head, occupations have genders.

And nobody asked me if I wanted that software installed.

Maybe it's because we grew up seeing men fixing everything.

When the TV acted up, Dad hit it.

When the sink leaked, an uncle appeared carrying a rusty toolbox that somehow solved every problem.

When there was a power outage, every man within a fifty meter radius suddenly became an electrical engineer.

Every estate has that one neighbour.

The transformer sneezes and before Kenya Power has even tweeted, he's already outside wearing sandals and holding a tester.

Nobody appointed him.

Nobody certified him.

Yet somehow everyone trusts him.

Women weren't absent.

They were doing equally important work.

But the jobs were divided in a way that quietly taught our brains,

"These jobs belong to men."

Children notice these things long before they understand them.

You don't sit a five year old down and explain gender roles.

They absorb them.

Who carries the ladder?

Who climbs onto the roof?

Who fixes the gate?

Who changes the tyre?

Who negotiates with fundis?

Who gets called when something heavy needs lifting?

After enough repetitions, your brain stops asking questions.

It starts making predictions.

And brains are lazy.

They love shortcuts.

See man.

Think expert.

See woman.

Need more evidence.

It's unfair.

It's irrational.

Yet there it is.

Our brains are weird.

We don't actually trust competence.

We trust signals.

White coat?

Doctor.

Suit?

Lawyer.

Grey hair?

Wise.

Deep voice?

Leader.

Tall person?

Authority.

Throw someone into overalls, hand them a toolbox, and suddenly they can convince half the estate they know plumbing.

Half the time they probably do.

The other half?

They're watching the same YouTube tutorial you watched yesterday.

I've realized my brain doesn't even ask,

"Who knows the most?"

It asks,

"Who looks like the person I'd expect to know the most?"

Those are completely different questions.

One is searching for competence.

The other is searching for familiarity.

Maybe the stereotype didn't appear out of nowhere.

For generations, more men really were mechanics.

More men really were fundis.

More men really did build houses.

More men really were electricians.

If that's what society looked like for decades, of course our brains learned the pattern.

The problem is that patterns have expiry dates.

Society changes.

Brains don't update automatically.

That's why a stereotype can survive long after reality has moved on.

Then life starts humbling you.

You ask a man in an electronics shop what the difference is between two TVs.

He scratches his head.

Reads the price tags.

Then starts reading the box.

Brother.

We're researching together.

I thought you worked here.

Then the lady you'd ignored walks over.

She explains OLED, refresh rates, panel technology, power consumption, warranty differences, and somehow throws in which model people keep returning because of software bugs.

You stand there thinking,

"So... I've been profiling excellence."

I've also noticed confidence plays tricks on us.

A man can confidently explain the wrong thing for fifteen straight minutes and somehow still sound like an expert.

A woman can explain the correct answer but sprinkle in,

"I think..."

"It depends..."

"In my experience..."

Somehow our brains hear uncertainty instead of knowledge.

Confidence is persuasive.

Accuracy is often quiet.

Unfortunately, they don't always travel together.

I've met mechanics who couldn't identify a dead battery if it introduced itself.

I've watched a female electrician explain a fault so clearly that three men standing nearby started nodding like they understood, yet none of them had a clue.

I've bought nyama choma from a man that tasted like he'd seasoned it with disappointment.

Then a lady at some roadside kibanda served me meat so good I briefly considered asking if she catered weddings.

Reality keeps trying to correct my assumptions.

My assumptions are stubborn.

And maybe that's the strange thing about bias.

It doesn't disappear because someone proves it wrong once.

Or twice.

Or even ten times.

Bias survives on habit.

It quietly whispers,

"Yeah... but that's probably an exception."

That's how stereotypes stay alive.

Not because they're always right.

Because every exception gets treated like an exception instead of evidence that the rule itself might be broken.

I've noticed something else that isn't flattering.

If a man installs my washing machine and it leaks, I think,

"Huyo fundi alikuwa mbaya."

If a woman installs it and it leaks, a tiny voice somewhere in my subconscious wants to think,

"Hmm... maybe women aren't that good at this."

One man's mistake belongs to him.

One woman's mistake quietly becomes evidence against every woman.

That's not fair.

But I wonder how many of us do that without ever realizing it.

Imagine waking up from a twenty year coma.

You walk into a hospital.

Your surgeon is a woman.

Your nurse is a man.

Your Uber driver is a grandmother.

The chef at the steakhouse is a petite lady.

The software engineer fixing your banking app has purple hair and wears Crocs.

The electrician who rewires your house is called Brenda.

The pilot welcoming you aboard is Captain Wanjiku.

You'd probably think the world had lost its mind.

Not because any of those people are unqualified.

Because your brain was frozen in a different version of reality.

Maybe that's what bias really is.

Yesterday's map trying to navigate today's roads.

We love pretending our biases don't exist because admitting them sounds like admitting we're bad people.

But bias isn't always hatred.

Sometimes it's inherited software.

Old programming.

A mental shortcut downloaded before you were old enough to question it.

Sometimes you don't even realize it's running until somebody asks,

"Why did you assume he'd know more?"

And all you have is,

"I... don't know."

That's probably the most uncomfortable answer.

Not because it makes you a bad person.

But because it reminds you how much of your thinking happens without asking your permission.

The problem isn't that the shortcut exists.

The problem is refusing to update it after life keeps sending software updates.

Maybe the woman in the electronics shop has ten years of experience.

Maybe Kevin is on his second day.

Maybe Faith has fixed a thousand showers.

Maybe Kamau's biggest qualification is owning overalls.

Maybe Susan's nyama choma deserves a Michelin star while Oti is surviving entirely on confidence.

Maybe the person who knows the most is simply the one standing in front of you.

So yes.

I still catch myself instinctively trusting men with certain jobs.

Not because I think women can't do them.

Because somewhere along the way, my brain quietly learned to associate competence with familiarity.

It's wrong often enough that I keep trying to unlearn it.

Pole pole.

My brain is updating.

The WiFi has been slow.

Now I'm curious.

What assumptions do you make without realizing it?

Because I refuse to believe mine are the only strange ones.

I simply happened to say mine out loud.